AUTO SPECIAL

FIRST DRIVE & RIDE

MOTORCYCLES

X MARKS THE SPOT

HARLEY-DAVIDSON HAS COLLABORATED WITH HERO MOTOCORP TO CREATE A MADE-FOR-INDIA MOTORCYCLE. WE JUST PUT IT THROUGH ITS PACES

BY RAHUL GHOSH



HARLEY DAVIDSON X440

There was a time when the Indian motorcycle market was dominated by Indo-Japanese makers. Today, however, it is European and American brands that are banking on Indian manufacturers to create a made-for and in-India motorcycle, all to get a piece of the country's huge market. The latest entrant is Harley-Davidson, which has created the Harley-Davidson X440 with Hero MotoCorp.

The X440 is a smart-looking motorcycle that seems to have derived inspiration from the Harley-Davidson Sportster range, especially the XR 1200X. The motorcycle rides on 18-inch MRF Zapper Hyke tyres, which are specifically developed for it and are fitted to diamond-cut alloy wheels. The short fender looks smart, and so do the chunky USD forks. The headlamp is all LED, complete with a signature LED DRL. It also features an 'auto on' function for riding in the dark.

The instrument panel is a single-pod all-digital affair. A small 3.5-inch TFT screen sits within the casing and offers information like speed, fuel level, engine speed and telltales. It also gets a trip computer and fuel efficiency calculator. The company has cleverly placed a USB charger right next to the instrument pod, which helps charge phones on the go. The X440 gets a raised and wide handlebar and the switchgear quality is good. The bike comes with a large 13.5-litre fuel tank with the Harley signature on the sides. The seat is also a wide and long, comfortable unit, with a very approachable 805 mm height. The rear fender has the LED tail light and the pillion grab rails. But, the gap between the 17-inch rear tyre and the fender seems odd. While the blacked-out engine looks good, the exhaust seems a bit big.

The X440 is a brand-new motorcycle and features a tubular steel perimeter frame. The engine is a long-stroke motor that displaces 440 cc and is oil-cooled. Power and torque figures are respectable at 27 bhp and 38 Nm. However, the clincher here is that all the torque comes in at 4,000 rpm. The engine sends power to the rear wheel using a 6-speed gearbox. The X440 uses 43 mm USD forks upfront and twin gas-charged shocks at the back. As for the brakes, the bike uses a 320 mm disc upfront and a 240 mm unit at the back, with dual-channel ABS.

Engine: 440 cc
Power: 27 bhp@6,000 rpm
Gearbox: 6-speed
Price: 2.69 lakh (ex-showroom)

The first thing I noticed was how easy it is to get on this 190.5 kg motorcycle. The seating position is just right with the foot pegs positioned in the middle instead of being rear- or forward-set. And with the wide handlebar, the X440 is surely a comfortable long-distance tourer. Thumb the starter and a rorty note emanates from the exhaust. The engine feels rev-happy and the gearbox slick. The clutch action is also light and should work wonders in traffic. Another great aspect is that the torque comes in at a very low rpm. This allows one to cruise at as low as 47 kmph in top gear. From then on, all that's needed is a twist of the throttle for the bike to take off. But the X440 is no slow coach. The motor redlines at roughly 6,500 rpm in almost every gear, and the acceleration is brisk too.

This is where we came back surprised. The X440 loves to dance and, around corners, it is a hoot to ride. The pegs scrape with ease and within no time, we chewed up the peg sliders around Hero MotoCorp's handling track at CIT, Jaipur. As far as ride quality is concerned, we didn't get rough patches around the facility, and will hence reserve our judgement till we get the bike for a ride on normal roads. But by the looks of it, we are sure the X440 will impress. ■